

Notes on the staff

Writing music, like writing words, evolved as a way of recording or fixing musical ideas or compositions. It enabled these ideas to be passed from one generation to another, or carried from one place to another.

The staff

When we write down a piece of music, or “notate” it, we use a staff consisting of five parallel lines. Notes are written on the staff, placing them higher or lower according to their pitch. The staff is the basic background element in nearly all music notation.



△ High and low on the staff

Higher-pitched notes go toward the top of the staff, while lower-pitched notes are placed toward the bottom.

Using staff lines and spaces

Notes are placed on the lines, or in the spaces between them. Below you can see notes written on each of the five lines of the staff (on the left), and in each of the four spaces (on the right). The staff in itself does not define the pitch of a written note; a clef is also needed.



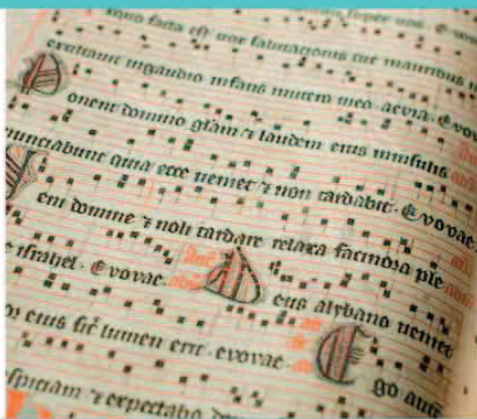
▽ Careful placing of notes

When writing music by hand, always be careful to make it clear whether the note head is on the line or in a space.

REAL WORLD

Evolution of the staff

Music was written by monks to help remember the melodies that accompanied religious texts. Early notation showed the shape of a melody—how the notes rise and fall—using marks placed above or below a single horizontal line. A more detailed picture of the rise and fall of a melody could be shown with more than one staff line. Early examples of written music used a four-line staff, but the five-line staff became standardized around 1500.



Single-line staves, or staves with two, three, or four lines, still have their uses. Percussion lines are often written on a one-line staff, because the information is rhythmic rather than melodic.